

Color & Contrast Guide for UI Designers

A practical color and contrast guide for UI designers covering color fundamentals, UI color roles, semantic colors, building a UI color palette, WCAG color contrast, accessible color, UI states, forms, dark mode, and practical color selection tips.

Who it's for

UI/UX students, beginner and junior UI designers, Figma users, web designers, and mobile app designers.

How to use it

Define color roles first, build your palette from them, test contrast early, then run the checklists before handoff.

Important

The sample HEX values are examples, not rules. Always test contrast with your own colors in real components.

QUICK UI COLOR REFERENCE · SAMPLE LIGHT THEME		
Quick UI Color Reference		
Role	Purpose	Example
Primary	Main brand and action color: primary buttons, links, active navigation	 #2563EB
Secondary	Supporting actions and elements that should stand out less than primary	 #0F766E
Accent	Small highlights: badges, promotions, key data points. Use sparingly	 #F59E0B
Background	The base canvas behind all content	 #F8FAFC
Surface	Cards, modals, menus, and inputs that sit on the background	 #FFFFFF
Text Primary	Headings and body text	 #0F172A
Text Secondary	Descriptions, helper text, metadata	 #475569
Border	Dividers (decorative) and input/control outlines (need contrast)	 #E2E8F0 ·  #64748B
Success	Completed actions, valid input, positive status	 #15803D
Warning	Caution, actions that need attention, pending issues	 #B45309
Error	Failed actions, invalid input, destructive actions	 #B91C1C
Information	Neutral notices, tips, and system messages	 #0369A1

01 Color Fundamentals

The basic color theory for UI design you'll use when picking and adjusting colors in Figma.

Hue The color itself: red, blue, green. It's the position on the color wheel (0–360° in HSL/HSB).	Saturation How intense or pure a color is. High saturation is vivid; low saturation is muted and closer to gray.	Brightness / value How light or dark a color is. Value differences, not hue, are what create contrast.
Tint A color mixed with white. Tints give you light backgrounds, such as a pale blue for a selected row.	Shade A color mixed with black. Shades are useful for hover, pressed states, and readable colored text.	Tone A color mixed with gray. Tones feel calmer and more professional than fully saturated colors.
Primary colors Red, yellow, blue in traditional color theory (red, green, blue for screens). All other colors are mixed from them.	Secondary colors Colors made by mixing two primaries: orange, green, purple. Not the same as a "secondary" UI role.	Neutral colors White, black, and grays (often slightly tinted). They make up most of a well-designed interface.

02 Color Roles in UI Design

A color role describes *what a color does*, not what it looks like. Designers should name colors by role (e.g. `text/secondary`) instead of picking a new color for every screen.

Role	What it's used for
Primary	The main action on a screen, links, active tabs, key brand moments.
Secondary	Supporting actions and elements that need less emphasis than primary.
Accent	Rare highlights that draw the eye: a "New" badge, a chart highlight.
Background	The page or app canvas.
Surface	Containers on top of the background: cards, sheets, dialogs, dropdowns.
Text primary	Headings and main reading text. Highest contrast.
Text secondary	Supporting text. Lower emphasis, but still readable.
Border	Dividers, card outlines, and input borders.
Disabled	Controls that can't be used right now.
Focus	The visible outline or ring showing keyboard focus.

Why roles matter: when every screen uses the same roles, the UI stays consistent, developers can map roles to design tokens, and changing a brand color or adding dark mode means updating one value instead of hundreds of layers.

03 UI Semantic Colors

Semantic colors carry meaning. Keep them reserved for that meaning so users learn to trust them.

Success

Saved, sent, completed, valid. Usually green.

Warning

Something needs attention but isn't broken yet. Usually amber or orange.

Error

Something failed or is invalid, or an action is destructive. Usually red.

Information

Neutral notices, tips, and updates. Usually blue.

Semantic meaning should not rely on color alone. Some users can't tell red from green, and colors can mean different things in different cultures. Pair semantic colors with an icon, a clear text label ("Error: email is required"), or both.

04 Creating a UI Color Palette

A simple, repeatable process for building a color palette for UI design.

1. **Choose a primary color** that fits the brand and works for buttons and links.

2. **Define supporting colors:** one secondary and, if needed, one accent.

3. **Create neutral colors:** a gray scale from near-white to near-black.

4. **Define text colors:** primary, secondary, and disabled text.

5. **Define surface/background colors** for the page, cards, and overlays.

6. **Define semantic colors:** success, warning, error, information.

7. **Test contrast** for every text/background and control combination.

8. **Document the color system** as Figma color styles or variables.

Example palette structure	Token name	Sample HEX	Notes
Primary	primary/600 · /700 · /800 · /50	#2563EB · #1D4ED8 · #1E40AF · #EFF6FF	Default, hover, active, selected background
Secondary	secondary/700	#0F766E	Supporting actions
Accent	accent/500	#F59E0B	Use with dark text, not white
Neutrals	neutral/50 – 900	#F8FAFC · #E2E8F0 · #94A3B8 · #64748B · #475569 · #0F172A	Backgrounds, borders, text
Text	text/primary · text/secondary	#0F172A · #475569	17.85:1 and 7.58:1 on white
Surfaces	bg/default · surface/default	#F8FAFC · #FFFFFF	Page and card
Semantic	success · warning · error · info	#15803D · #B45309 · #B91C1C · #0369A1	Each is 5:1 or higher on white

05 Text & Background Contrast

Contrast is the difference in lightness between foreground and background. Low contrast makes text hard to read for everyone, especially on phones outdoors, on low-quality screens, and for people with low vision.

4.5:1 Normal text · AA minimum	3:1 Large text · AA minimum	7:1 Normal text · AAA (enhanced)	4.5:1 Large text · AAA (enhanced)
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Topic	Practical guidance (WCAG 2.x)
Text vs background	Body text, labels, links, and button text should meet at least 4.5:1 against their background (Success Criterion 1.4.3, Level AA).
Large vs normal text	"Large text" is at least 18pt (about 24px) regular, or 14pt (about 18.66px) bold. Large text needs at least 3:1 for AA.
Enhanced (AAA)	7:1 for normal text and 4.5:1 for large text (SC 1.4.6). A good target for long reading content.
UI components	Visual information needed to identify a control or its state (input borders, checkbox outlines, toggle states, focus indicators) should meet 3:1 against adjacent colors (SC 1.4.11, WCAG 2.1+). Meaningful icons and chart elements follow the same 3:1 guideline.
Disabled states	Inactive (disabled) controls are exempt from contrast requirements. They should still look clearly disabled and remain legible where possible.
Borders & controls	Decorative dividers don't need 3:1. But if a border is the only thing showing where an input is, it does. Example: <code>#E2E8F0</code> on white is 1.23:1 (fine for a divider), <code>#64748B</code> is 4.76:1 (fine for an input border).

Requirements differ by content and context. Logos, purely decorative elements, and text inside inactive controls are exempt; text over images or gradients must be checked at its lowest-contrast point. WCAG measures contrast with a specific formula, so check with a contrast tool rather than by eye. Contrast is one part of accessibility, not the whole of it.

06 Accessible Color

An accessible color palette works for people with color vision deficiencies, low vision, and varied screens.

- **Don't use color as the only indicator** of meaning, state, or required action (WCAG SC 1.4.1, Level A).
- **Add icons, labels, patterns, or text** where appropriate: an error icon with a message, underlined links in body text, patterns or direct labels in charts.
- **Check text/background contrast** for every text style and every background it appears on.
- **Check interactive states:** hover, active, and selected states should remain readable and distinguishable.
- **Check focus indicators:** keyboard focus must be visible on every interactive element, with a clearly contrasting outline or ring.
- **Test color combinations** with a contrast checker and a color-blindness simulator (for example, Figma plugins or browser dev tools).

07 UI States

Use the same color logic for states across every component so users recognize them instantly.

State	How color is typically used
Default	The base role color, e.g. <code>primary/600</code> .
Hover	One step darker (or lighter in dark mode), e.g. <code>primary/700</code> . Not available on touch screens, so never put meaning only here.
Focus	A visible ring or outline, often 2px with a small offset, in a color that contrasts with both the component and the background.
Active / pressed	Darker still, e.g. <code>primary/800</code> , for instant feedback on click or tap.
Selected	A light tint background with stronger text or a check icon, e.g. <code>primary/50</code> + <code>primary/700</code> text.
Disabled	Neutral, low-emphasis colors plus a non-color cue (no pointer, reduced visual weight).
Error	Error color for border and message, plus an icon and descriptive text.
Success	Success color for border or message, plus an icon and confirmation text.

Example: primary button color system

Button state	Background	Text	Other
Default	 #2563EB	#FFFFFF (5.17:1)	—
Hover	 #1D4ED8	#FFFFFF (6.70:1)	Cursor: pointer
Focus	 #2563EB	#FFFFFF	2px #2563EB ring, 2px offset (4.94:1 on #F8FAFC)
Active	 #1E40AF	#FFFFFF (8.72:1)	—
Disabled	 #E2E8F0	#94A3B8	Exempt from contrast; not clickable

Default

Hover

Focus

Active

Disabled

08 Color in Forms

Forms are where color mistakes cause real problems: missed errors, unreadable hints, and inputs users can't find.

Element	Color guidance
Input borders	If the border is what shows the input's boundary, aim for 3:1 against the background (e.g. <code>#64748B</code> on white).
Labels	Use text primary or text secondary colors that meet 4.5:1. Keep labels visible above the field.
Placeholder text	Often lighter than input text. If it gives users information, it should still meet 4.5:1.
Focus states	A clear border color change plus a ring or thicker border, so focus doesn't depend on a subtle hue shift.
Error messages	Error color for border and text, an error icon, and a message that explains how to fix it.
Success messages	Success color plus a check icon and text. Use them sparingly, e.g. for confirmed usernames or completed steps.
Required fields	Mark with an asterisk or "(required)" text, not only a red label. Explain the asterisk at the top of the form.

Placeholder text should not replace labels. It disappears when users start typing, so they forget what the field was for. It's usually low-contrast, and it isn't reliably announced by all screen readers. Use a visible label, and use placeholders only for optional format hints.

09 Dark Mode

Dark mode is a second color theme built from the same roles, not an inverted copy of light mode.

Avoid simply inverting colors

Inverting breaks brand colors, shadows, and semantic meaning. Redefine each role for dark backgrounds.

Use appropriate surface colors

Use dark grays such as `#0B1120` for background and `#1E293B` for surfaces. Lighter surfaces show elevation.

Reduce excessive pure white

Large areas of `#FFFFFF` text on black can glare. Off-white like `#F1F5F9` is softer and still high contrast.

Check text contrast

Re-test every text color. `#CBD5E1` on `#1E293B` is 9.85:1; mid-grays often fail on dark surfaces.

Check borders

Borders that looked fine in light mode may disappear. `#64748B` on `#1E293B` is 3.07:1.

Check semantic colors

Saturated reds and greens usually need lighter versions on dark backgrounds, e.g. `#F87171` error (5.29:1).

Review images and illustrations

Check logos, illustrations with white backgrounds, and charts. Provide dark versions where needed.

Test all interactive states

Hover, focus, active, selected, and disabled all need their own dark-mode values and testing.

10 Common Color Mistakes

- ✗ Too many colors with no clear roles

✗ Poor contrast between text and background

✗ Overusing accent colors until nothing stands out

✗ Using color without semantic meaning (e.g. red for decoration)
- ✗ Inconsistent hover, focus, and selected states

✗ Extremely saturated colors everywhere

✗ Ignoring dark mode until the end

✗ Using color alone to communicate information

11 Color Accessibility Checklist

Use this checklist to confirm your UI color guidelines meet basic accessibility needs.

☐ Text contrast checked (4.5:1 for normal text)

☐ Large text contrast checked (3:1)

☐ Interactive elements checked (3:1 for boundaries and states)

☐ Focus states checked and clearly visible

☐ Error states checked (color + icon + text)

☐ Success states checked (color + icon + text)

☐ Color is not the only indicator

☐ Dark mode checked where applicable

☐ Disabled states reviewed

☐ Color palette documented

12 Quick UI Color Reference (Dark Theme Sample)

The light-theme reference is on page 1. Here are the same roles adapted for dark mode.

Role	Purpose	Example
Background	App canvas	#0B1120
Surface	Cards, menus, dialogs	#1E293B
Text Primary	Headings and body	#F1F5F9 (13.35:1 on surface)
Text Secondary	Supporting text	#CBD5E1 (9.85:1 on surface)
Primary	Buttons and links; use dark text on it	#60A5FA (5.75:1 on surface)
Border	Input and control outlines	#64748B (3.07:1 on surface)
Semantic	Success · Warning · Error · Info	#4ADE80 · #FBBF24 · #F87171 · #38BDF8

13 Beginner Color Tips

Start with fewer colors

One primary, a neutral scale, and four semantic colors are enough for most products.

Build a neutral palette first

Most of a UI is gray, white, and text. Get neutrals right and the brand color has room to shine.

Define color roles

Name colors by job (`text/secondary`) not appearance (`gray-light-2`).

Test contrast early

Fixing contrast after 50 screens are designed is much harder than at the palette stage.

Use semantic colors consistently

Red always means error or danger, never "just a nice highlight".

Don't choose colors only because they look attractive

A color must also be readable, meaningful, and work in every state.

Test colors in real UI components

Swatches look different from buttons, forms, and charts. Test in context.

Document your color system in Figma

Use color styles or variables, with light and dark modes, and share them with developers.

★ Quick 10-Point Color Review

Run through this before handing off a UI color system to developers.

☐ Every color has a defined role

☐ Primary color is used mainly for key actions

☐ Accent color is used sparingly

☐ Body and label text meet 4.5:1

☐ Input borders and icons meet 3:1

☐ All states (hover, focus, active, selected, disabled) are defined

☐ Semantic colors are paired with icons or text

☐ Focus is visible on every interactive element

☐ Dark mode values are defined and tested (if supported)

☐ Colors are saved as Figma styles/variables with clear names